

Lesson 17

Politeness in Professional Requests

 Warm-Up

1. Can you describe a time when you had to make a request at work?
2. How did you approach the situation?
3. What was the outcome?





Role-Play

Scenario: *Daniel is requesting a meeting with his supervisor, Kath.*

Daniel: Hi, Kath. Do you have a minute?

Kath: Hi, Daniel. Yes, what's up?

Daniel: I was wondering if I could schedule a meeting with you to discuss the upcoming project. *Would it be convenient if* you'll be attending the meeting with the team this week?

Pia: I am available to meet on Wednesday at 2 PM. Would that work for the team?

Daniel: Most of the team members are available on Wednesday at 3 PM. *I'd appreciate it if* you could adjust your availability one hour later. Would that be fine?

Kath: That is doable, Daniel. See you and the team then on Wednesday at 3 PM.

Daniel: Great! Thanks, Kath!

Role-Play Analysis

Answer the following questions:

1. How did Daniel feel when making a request?
2. What polite language did he use?
3. How did Kath respond?
4. What would you do differently next time?



Vocabulary: Direct vs. Indirect Requests

1. **Softening Language** – used to reduce directness of a message, making it less confrontational or aggressive.

Examples:

- **Direct Request** – I need the report by Friday.
- **Indirect / Softened** – *I was wondering if* it would be possible to get the report by Friday?
- **Direct Request** – You need to provide feedback on this report.
- **Indirect / Softened** – *I'd appreciate it if* you could provide feedback on this report.

2. **Formal Phrasing** – the use of polite, professional, and objective language in written or spoken communication, particularly in formal or business settings.

Examples:

- **Direct Request** – Can you help me?
- **Indirect / Formal** – *I would appreciate it if* you could assist me with this matter.
- **Direct Request** – Can you submit the latest sales figures?
- **Indirect / Formal** – *Could you please* provide me with the latest sales figures?



Practice

Activity 1: *Convert the following direct requests into indirect or softened requests.*

1. Send me the minutes of the last meeting.
2. Book a flight for the business trip.
3. Finish the project by the end of the month.
4. Cover my shift on Saturday.
5. Change the company's social media policy.
6. Finish this report by Friday.
7. Book a meeting room for the conference.
8. Send me the sales data by the end of the day.
9. Cover the customer service phone line.
10. Change the project deadline.

Activity 2: *To practice using polite language, take turns reading the dialogue and answering the questions provided.*

Scenario: Requesting a change in work schedule.

Kath: Hi Daniel, I wanted to touch base with you about my work schedule. Would it be possible to discuss a potential change?

Daniel: What kind of change are you thinking of Kath?

Kath: I'd appreciate it if I could start my day at 10am instead of 8am. I have some personal commitments that I need to attend to in the mornings.

Daniel: I understand. Let me check the team's schedule. Could you please provide me with some alternative dates for when you'd like to start a new schedule?

Kath: That would be great, thank you. If it's not too much trouble, could we discuss this further in a meeting?

Daniel: I'd be happy to meet you. How about we schedule a meeting for tomorrow at 2 PM?

Discussion Questions:

1. What polite language was used in the request?
2. How did the tone of the conversation change when using polite language?
3. What are the benefits of using polite language in professional requests?



Production

To help you feel more confident and prepared when making professional requests, answer the following questions.

1. What's the difference between being direct and being indirect in making requests? Give an example.
2. How do you handle requests that are unclear or ambiguous? Can you walk me through your process?
3. How do you handle requests that are outside of your job description or expertise? Can you walk me through your process?
4. How can you handle situations where someone is not responding to your polite requests?
5. What can you do if a polite request is misinterpreted in a different culture?



Homework

Instructions: Read the workplace scenarios and identify whether the request is direct or indirect. Then, rewrite the direct requests to make them indirect.

1. Can you finish the product design layout by tomorrow? (Direct / Indirect)
2. I'd appreciate it if you could review the contract. (Direct / Indirect)
3. Can you help me with the presentation? (Direct / Indirect)
4. Send me your feedback by the end of the day. (Direct / Indirect)
5. Would it be possible to finish the project by the end of the month? (Direct / Indirect)